



Simplifying Fractions

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Simplifying Fractions

The final answer to a problem should be simplified, or written in lowest terms. A fraction is in lowest terms when there is no number that can evenly divide both the numerator and the denominator except for 1.

Example

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Write $\frac{10}{15}$ in lowest terms.

Step 1
Think: What number can both 10 and 15 be divided by? Both can be divided by 5.

Step 2
Write 1 as a fraction using 5 as both the numerator and the denominator.

$$1 = \frac{5}{5}$$

Step 3
Divide $\frac{10}{15}$ by $\frac{5}{5}$.

$$\frac{10}{15} \div \frac{5}{5} = \frac{10 \div 5}{15 \div 5} = \frac{2}{3}$$

Step 4
Use cross products to check your work.

$$\frac{10}{15} = \frac{2}{3}$$
$$15 \times 2 = 30$$
$$10 \times 3 = 30$$

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Lesson 4: Fraction Basics